

# The Good and the Holy

## *On the Twofold Space of Religious Meaning*

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*"Kodesh is a word unto itself, and the rest come from it."*[1]

Zohar, part III, 61b

*"What is hateful to you, do not do to your fellow. This is the whole Torah, and the rest is commentary."*[2]

Shabbat 31a

### Preface

Our religious concepts, like the semantic space as a whole, are woven into one another like an intricate web, such that the meaning of any one concept can only be explicated by way of the many other concepts bound up with it. In the early twentieth century, positivist philosophers and logicians dreamed of a systematic, hierarchical organization of our entire lexicon, so that we would begin from a small list of "primitive," axiomatic concepts, and would gradually define, by means of them and of what is derived from them, all the words we might wish to use — much as mathematicians built up geometry. But this ambition failed. It turned out that whenever we try to define a given term, we necessarily use other terms that we take as already known and understood, in order to convey its meaning. If we were purists and sought, again and again, to define those other terms too, clearly and unambiguously, at some stage in the process we would find ourselves going in a circle; it seems there is no way to describe language as derived from a small set of primitive words, but rather as composed, in an almost-complete way, of the totality of all words and concepts together, and of the network of contexts and relations that hold among them.

Nevertheless, in order to sharpen, to the fullest possible degree, the idea at the base of this essay, I will make momentary use of that hierarchical foundational assumption in order to pose the question — what is the basic concept, the axiom, the cornerstone, of the Jewish religious worldview? I will argue that this question has two different, competing answers, both of which hover throughout the world of Judaism, in all its length and breadth, and which give rise to two distinct religious fields, or spaces. According to one answer, spelled out in the words of the Zohar cited above, everything begins and cascades from holiness (kodesh); according to another answer, exemplified in the words of Hillel the Elder, everything grows from the good (tov). I will try to clarify the meanings of each of these foundational positions — what kind of perception, experience and religious conduct each of them entails, and where they come into clash and

contradiction. Moreover, the crux of my argument will be that, despite the essential contradiction between these two religious spaces, it is vital that we preserve both of them together in order to compose our religious world.

## A.

In the Socratic dialogue Euthyphro,[3] an intriguing dilemma is formulated that would accompany theology and religious philosophy for centuries afterward. In trying to define, at Socrates' request, "what piety is" — that is, what makes some act into "the right act," the good one, the one worth doing — Euthyphro, Socrates' interlocutor, seeks to lean on a religious criterion: "what is loved by the gods — that is piety." [4] In response to this answer, Socrates raises the following question:

*Is [1] piety loved [by the gods] because it is piety, or [2] is it piety because it is loved? [5]*

Euthyphro chooses option [1], according to which the gods' love of piety is a result of piety's own inner, essential nature as something positive. Because of this answer, Socrates confronts him with his own initial definition, of piety as identical with "what is loved by the gods"; for now, the gods' love turns out to be merely a "coincidence" that happens to that piety, rather than its constitutive definition. It follows that piety must be characterized by what it is in its own nature — by what it is, in itself, that the gods love about it — rather than by its being an object of the gods' love.

The transposition of this issue from Socrates' Hellenistic-pagan world to a Jewish-monotheistic world is not trivial, but it seems the dilemma still echoes within us, in the relation between the concept of "piety" or "the good" and the concept of "the will of God," and in the question of the logical, or evaluative, priority of one over the other. On the one side [1] stands a conception according to which the good is the most primary category in our world, possessing essence and existence in its own right. We know the good by way of our moral sense, and out of that sense we harness ourselves to the service of God, who is the God of goodness, righteousness and justice, and we seek to do His will, which, too — by our faith — is identical with the good. On the other side [2], there stands an opposite conception, according to which all our talk of "the good" is but another name, a synonym, for doing the will of God, which is the foundation and root of every turn we make. God commands, and we are obligated to His word, seeing in His command guidance and illumination toward the way of righteousness and goodness. God's revelation as commander does not overlap with any inner human sense or natural-human content; He appears as a supreme God, Owner of heaven and earth, emerging from the heavens of majesty and nobility and disclosing to us His hidden will. Accordingly, the foundational category in this picture is transcendent holiness, and the concepts of goodness, uprightness and the entire lexicon belonging to the normative domain are perceived as a projection, or a translation, of holiness into our human world.

We can also name these two possibilities with a pair of spatial-directional images that help us picture the opposition between them. The possibility of the primacy of the good [1] will be called "bottom-up" — the foundation of everything is the good, in the same basic human sense in which human beings grasp it "from below," even within an autonomous world that exists in its own right; and out of that same natural essence, God desires it and identifies with it. The possibility of the primacy of holiness [2], by contrast, will be called "top-down" — since the content defined as the way of righteousness and correctness originates, first of all, in the heavenly, in the inconceivable divine, which reveals itself to us and directs our gaze toward what is good in His eyes, such that it is to be called good. When one speaks, on this picture, of good and evil, of what is fitting and correct, one speaks of something that is always in the category of interpretation and explication of the content of revelation and command, and not necessarily of what the autonomous human being would define and feel to be good or moral.

## **B.**

### "Bottom-Up" Religiosity — How?

The Jewish story begins with God's turning to Abraham our father. The background to this turning is not made explicit in the story, but if we wait for the following passage, we find that God declares that the choosing of Abraham came about because of Abraham's own choice of the way of "piety" and doing good —

*"For I have known him, to the end that he may command his children and his household after him, that they may keep the way of the LORD, to do righteousness and justice."*[6]

Throughout the Bible, God presents Himself as operating within a framework of moral categories, and conducts, with man, a dialogue on the basis of this assumption. Because of this, biblical figures — from the great figures of the nation, such as Abraham our father and Moses our teacher, to figures such as Abimelech king of Gerar, Job and Cain — more than once stood before God, argued with Him and raised moral arguments against Him.[7] In some of these cases, God yielded to the argument and changed His ways; in others, He remained with His original judgment and decreed as He saw fit; but in all these cases, He regarded claims from the human-moral field as relevant arguments that needed to be addressed. Furthermore, Scripture repeatedly accompanies God's commands with moral and emotional justifications,[8] and declares, on various occasions, that the purpose of divine law is kindness, righteousness and justice.[9]

Of course, there is theological difficulty in identifying God's will with the moral good familiar to us from the human-natural field of cognition. In a certain sense, such an identification is impossible, since it subjects the divine to the fetters of a finite, contingent, limited humanity. We will expand on this point further below, but the initial response of the primacy-of-the-good conception will be that indeed, the moral will is precisely the place where created being breaks

through its own boundaries and draws directly from infinite divine perfection; this is the "image of God" (tzelem Elohim) with which man is endowed, and indeed it should not be seen as an arbitrary bundle of culture-bound, time-and-place-dependent moral ideas, or as a result of autobiographical, psychological conditioning and constructs, but rather as a spark of the divine soul within man. In this, this conception gives expression to the second part of the "bottom-up" image — the religious picture of the world does not merely add content of divine revelation to natural human obligation, but rather elevates that very circle of natural obligation to the heavenly heights of divine sublimity.

Natural morality, then, receives an unchallengeable position of primacy, since it embodies the side of human personality that, by its very nature, is connected to the divine. This has implications for the entire picture of the world — religious, spiritual and halakhic; for the scales of values by which a person acts in the world, and for the way conflicts between religion and morality are approached. Normatively, the traditional halakha-observant person will prefer compliance with the religious command — whose source, ultimately, lies in the divine revelation at Mount Sinai — over such and other moral intuitions that, in a given case, do not align with it. But this religious movement of submission before the divine command is not the end of the conflict, but rather the first stage of a deep process of inner ferment and psychic upheaval. From the starting point of the good, and of the identity of the divine will with the good, a reality in which there is a contradiction between the subjective, personal hue of moral goodness and the religious sources is a reality that demands penetrating examination and clarification. The person is called to engage in genuine dialogue with such a contradiction — to clarify how it arose and what the most fitting way out of it is. This clarification will always weigh two alternatives against each other. On the one hand, it is possible that the religious sources, or more precisely the accepted interpretation of them, do not fully reflect the true content of the original divine revelation; that an error crept in, or a deviation occurred, from the way the word of God ought to be understood in present-day reality. On the other hand, it is possible that the initial moral intuitions do not reflect the good in the best possible way, and are skewed by a host of cultural, social and psychological causes. Essentially, the two alternatives do not exclude one another, and so in most confrontations between religion and morality a person will find himself walking both paths at once. Such confrontations require the person to engage in constant "pipe-cleaning" — cleaning the pipe through which the original divine revelation passes on its way to the concrete halakhic ruling in the case at hand, and cleaning the pipe through which the person draws his moral insights from the well of inner listening to the pure soul that dwells in the hidden recesses.

The belief that identifies God's will with the good shapes the experience of fulfilling the religious command in a particular way. Even though the command does not always shine with some clear and transparent good, and a person usually does not feel toward it the same deep moral intuition that he feels toward acts such as kindness, gratitude or a gracious countenance, the person's basic psychic bond to the command is directed at that very same place directed toward doing good and right. The person seeks to fulfill the word of God out of free will and full

identification. He keeps the commandments out of a positive, even exhilarating, belief that in doing so he is doing something good — something that advances, repairs, elevates — not only his own soul and life, but also his fellow and the whole world. He consciously mobilizes all the higher parts of his soul for the service of God, so as not to fall into sin. The inner struggle before the word of God is a struggle between good and evil, between the high and the low; religious sin is a moral, personal transgression, a fall by the person into behavior that he feels to be shameful and guilty even between himself and himself, and not only before God.

This experience also colors the interpretive horizon that a person grants to the commandments and their reasons (ta'amei mitzvot), and, more broadly, to the halakhic tradition from foundation to capstone. Any engagement with the reasons for the commandments assumes — whether as a starting point or as a desired goal — that there is a moral-human perspective for the meaning of the divine commandments. Some of the medieval sages who dealt with the reasons for the commandments said as much explicitly, such as, for example, Maimonides:

*And there is one who says that every command and prohibition among them [among the commandments] is the result of wisdom, and its purpose is some specific end, and that all the commandments have a reason, and that He commanded them because of some specific benefit [...] that they all have a reason, and we simply do not know the reasons for some of them, nor do we know the manner of the wisdom in them — this is the view of all of us, the multitude and the elite alike, and the language of the text on this is clear: "righteous statutes and judgments," "the judgments of the LORD are true, they are righteous altogether." [10]*

All the commandments have a beneficial purpose, even if in some of them we do not, at first glance, grasp what it is. From this understanding follows a theoretical program for seeking out the reasons for the commandments — not in order to make the fulfillment of the command conditional upon its reason, but in order to understand correctly what the divine wisdom was in giving this command, and in order to ground in the heart the belief that "it is not an empty thing."

Among another group of medieval sages who dealt with the reasons for the commandments, the picture is more complex and blurred, and they refrain from declaring that every commandment has a purposive reason that can be uncovered and understood by a human being. Yet, in practice, whoever sought to bring the commandments closer to reason did so in order to enable and strengthen inner identification with the commandments — an inner identification in which is embedded the identification between the good and the will of God.

Beyond the reasons for the commandments, which to some degree remain outside the circle of halakhic discourse proper, the consciousness of the "primacy of the good," as noted, also colors the entire interpretive-halakhic orientation of the person. The unfolding of halakha as a ramified legal system has led to a situation in which the details of the laws do indeed have an "access

path" from the commandments and the general foundational principles, but in many cases this path is, intuitively, blurred and winding. In other words, halakhic discourse and its many clauses appear to stand on their own, as an internal language, and it is hard to understand "where to go" from within the broad range of possibilities and disputes spread before anyone who wishes, through study, to arrive at "the will of God." In such a state, the halakhic decisor, and anyone walking the paths of practical halakhic discussion, must adopt some external, a-priori vantage point that clarifies and illuminates the paths of the discussion; he must have some intuitive anchor that guides him toward "the correct conclusion," navigating his way through the abundant tangle of halakhic arguments and sources. The consciousness that identifies the good with the will of God serves as just such an intuitive anchor; the person sees his moral understanding and intuition as a central tool for understanding the meaning of the components of the halakhic system, and, more than that, as a basic compass meant to direct the process of halakhic interpretation in the correct direction.

A "bottom-up" religious consciousness places man before God as a partner; God calls upon man to govern the world — "fill the earth and subdue it, and rule over the fish of the sea and the birds of the sky and every creeping thing that creeps upon the earth" — to be responsible for His creatures and to establish justice and righteousness in the land. In the relationship between man and God, God is the lawgiver and the sovereign, but at the same time also man's teacher and guide, whose purpose is not only to serve God but to do what is needed so that the world may be repaired and elevated, "for our good, all the days." A single overarching goal — the absolute good — binds man together with God and instills between them a relationship of friendship and partnership.

### **C.**

"Top-Down" religiosity instills a religious space and a religious consciousness that are entirely different in all these dimensions.

The Jewish story of election begins, not by accident, with a divine call preceded by no explanation whatsoever. God chooses Abraham, and his seed after him, out of an obscure will, a "desire" (cheshek) — "It was not because you were more numerous than any other people that the LORD desired (chashak) you and chose you." [11] The divine election, like the divine will in general, cannot be explained or understood by any tool fashioned within our finite world; the gap between God's ways and human understanding cannot be bridged — "For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are My ways higher than your ways, and My thoughts than your thoughts." [12]

Throughout the Bible, God presents Himself as a great and awesome God, who is subject to no law other than His own will. When human beings laid out their claims before Him, He more than once reminded them of their place, and of their inability to "step into His shoes" and understand the full breadth of the picture from within which He acts —

*Then the LORD answered Job out of the whirlwind, and said: Who is this that darkens counsel by words without knowledge? Gird up now your loins like a man, for I will demand of you, and you shall declare unto Me. Where were you when I laid the foundations of the earth? Declare, if you have understanding. Who determined its measurements, if you know, or who stretched a line upon it? [...] Have the gates of death been revealed unto you, or have you seen the gates of the shadow of death? Have you comprehended the breadth of the earth? Declare, if you know it all.[13]*

One cannot speak of a utilitarian purpose for the divine command. The Torah is not occupied with justifying its statutes and laws in human terms; for the most part it is a legal document that creates absolute obligation by force of the holiness of what is written in it, by force of the prophetic truth that produced it. The Torah is a truth that preceded the world; revelation did not come to expose some inner logic that would also be available to man through his own natural reason, but rather to disclose a noble secret whose source lies above and beyond our limited world, to elevate being by binding it to the infinite. As in the story of the Garden of Eden, the foundational decision man must make is whether to heed the voice of God commanding him, or to follow his own eyes and heart. The worldview of "the primacy of holiness" increasingly contrasts the ordinary human content of life with holiness, revelation and the indwelling of the Shekhinah. Life standing on its own, cut off from divine revelation and the observance of the commandments, is no longer worthy; the ideal placed at the heart of life calls for rising beyond the natural, beyond whatever the human heart, with all its weaknesses, desires and craves.

Natural morality, on this conception, has no status more special than any of man's other inclinations and attainments. All natural-human baggage stands opposite revelation, whose purpose is to sanctify man and redeem him from the smallness and limitation of the narrow world in which he lives. Just as the prohibition of forbidden sexual relations demands that a person overcome his desire, so too can other commandments — as the Binding of Isaac teaches us — demand the overcoming of feelings of love and kindness, and of various moral intuitions. There is no doubt that the inner conflict is sharper in such cases — and it is not for nothing that the Akedah was the final and ultimate trial through which Abraham passed before being called "God-fearing"[14] — but it is entirely clear what the good, correct thing to do is: to heed the voice of God without any reservation or condition.

The conception of God's will as a transcendent revelation that has nothing to do with human-earthly tendencies, intuitions and conceptions leaves a deep imprint on the experience of fulfilling the religious command, and on its understanding and interpretation. While the "bottom-up" religious person strives for an experience of identification with the commandment, from its general purpose down to its details, the "top-down" religious person prefers the experience of absolute compliance, and the supreme value in his life is self-sacrifice (*mesirut nefesh*). He never dares picture himself as a partner to God's secret; the hierarchy between the earthly and the heavenly is preserved at every step — "the heavens are the heavens of the

LORD, but the earth He has given to the children of man." [15] From this conception, identification with a commandment, or one understanding or another of its reason, neither adds nor detracts; even commandments whose reason seems, on the face of it, transparent or natural, such as honoring one's parents or giving charity to the poor, are more properly fulfilled not out of identification and natural inclination, but out of the pursuit of holiness and the desire to do the will of God, the wish to make His holy presence manifest on earth.

As a consequence, one should avoid, as much as possible, mixing intuitive human conceptions into the process of Torah study and halakhic ruling. Halakha is conceived as the embodiment of God's sublime command, as it was revealed from the heights of Mount Sinai and given to Moses orally, and in whose shaping human reason has only the smallest place. This outlook on the Oral Torah creates a tension between the intellectual character of Torah study and its purpose of reflecting the word of God without human touch. The Torah scholar is thus called upon to refine his soul of bad character traits, to be ascetic and pure and to direct his whole heart to Heaven. Beyond this, his "Torah training" includes not only erudition and broad knowledge of all the Torah's secrets, but also service to Torah scholars, intended to help him acquire a "Torah mind" — an intellectual and intuitive skill that is not innate or natural from birth, but is shaped by the scholarly-halakhic discourse as it passes down, by tradition, from generation to generation.

Beyond the wish to preserve the "purity of the holy" of interpretive Torah work from personal, cultural and historical touches, the conception that opposes holiness to natural-human content also pushes interpretation toward a horizon that supports this opposition — perhaps only semi-consciously. If an inner experience of righteousness and goodness is not perceived as intuitive confirmation of "the rightness of the path," as a compass one may consult in the forest of interpretive possibilities of Torah discourse, then there is a necessity to seek some other inner experience to fill this role — the experience of holiness and of surrender to the will of a supreme God. But what is the psychic content of these concepts, when, by their very definition, we assume that they are foreign to man and beyond his grasp? The salient possibility is to take the very foreignness to the inner world as a measure of holiness — to see alienation as an indication that a leap toward the infinite has been made, that religious devotion is complete. The religious worldview, and the Torah-interpretive discourse bound up with it, are now inwardly directed toward contents that will increase alienation, the gap between the holy and the human, between revelation and the heart's inclination.

## **D.**

The gap between the two approaches sharpens still further when we turn to the most foundational religious question of all, the question of the divine attributes. What theology does each approach develop? How does theology bear on the question of the primacy of the good over the primacy of the holy, or, alternatively, how is it shaped by that question?

The dual face of God in Judaism is evident in many sources. In the Kedushah prayer we stress — "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of Hosts" — God is sublime and exalted above and beyond all place



and limitation; and yet — "the whole earth is full of His glory." In esoteric literature, this dual face is given names such as "He who surrounds all worlds" and "He who fills all worlds"; and in modern scholarship, it is customary to call the different aspects of the God-world relationship by the terms "transcendence" and "immanence." In short, we constantly find the divine concept stretched and struggling between two poles — the Nothing, the holy, the undefined and the sublime on the one hand, and the root of being, the life of life and the substrate of finite existence on the other. The question that always remains without a full answer is to what degree God participates in the essence of the things He created, and to what degree He is exalted and elevated above them to the point of having no relation to them at all.

Every school of thought belonging to the mainstream of Judaism is therefore obligated to contain both these faces in its picture of the Creator. At the same time, as one might expect, the two opposing approaches regarding the relationship between the good and the holy also diverge on the basis of which pole they take to be more significant in conceiving the relationship between God and the world — and, in effect, on how content is to be given to the concept of divinity at all. The "bottom-up" approach will focus its religious gaze on the "divine attributes," or the "divine ideals" — the qualities by which God's ways of acting are to be described, and to which one must cleave in order to fulfill the commandment of walking in His ways and cleaving to Him. It will be careful to keep its distance from describing the divine essence itself, but will insist that the main thing is to fill the heart with the positive image of the good-light radiating from His attributes — which is the handle by which the divine concept can be "drawn" into our world, into our lives. The psychic content of the concept of God, then, is meant to arrive from the warm, human, living realms of feeling; it is, in practice, a projection of the best thing one can inwardly recognize onto a special name defined by just that — the name of God. Everything pictured in human consciousness as good thereby receives — bottom-up, as noted — also the splendor of the divine title.

By contrast, the "top-down" approach will insist on the distinction and the gap between the human contents attached to the concept of the divine and God's hidden being. It will not be satisfied with a mere declarative reservation against ascribing positive, human-like attributes to God, but will place that very reservation at the heart of the experience of apprehending God. For this approach, the central content with which the soul fills the concept of divinity lies in the negation of all positive content regarding God, and in a conceptual-psychic distancing between Him and any attribute or content that could touch upon human finitude and corporeality. God is what He is — "I will be what I will be" — and what we know about Him is that we know nothing about Him, that He is hidden in a supreme and sublime holy majesty, beyond anything we could ever apprehend. Philosophically, such an approach found complete expression in Maimonides' doctrine of negative attributes, according to which, beyond the bare fact of God's existence, all advancement in apprehending Him is in fact a retreat from apprehending Him through limiting human depictions:

*One who asks may ask and say: If there is no device for grasping the truth of His essence, and the demonstrative proof teaches that what is grasped is only that He*

*exists, and that positive attributes are impossible, as has been demonstrated by proof — in what, then, does the difference in rank between those who grasp Him consist? [...] Know, then, that this is indeed so: the difference in rank between those who apprehend is very great. For with every increase in the attributes ascribed to the described thing, it becomes more particular, and the describer draws nearer to a grasp of its true reality. Likewise, the more you add in negation regarding Him, exalted be He, the closer you come to apprehension, and you are nearer to it than one who has not negated of Him that whose negation has been demonstrated to you by proof.*

Guide of the Perplexed, I:59

This path of advancement in apprehending God through negating His attributes sounds like a circular route, or a dead end — but in truth, from the soul's own perspective, negation is not merely an absence of content, but content in its own right; it is what lies beyond words or imagination, beyond the very edge of self-aware, discursive consciousness. According to the Kabbalah, "Ein" (Nothing) is a name for a mode of revelation that is higher than what enters the vessel of our consciousness, and yet we have a bond and a belonging to it, from the hidden strata of the soul, which indeed lie beyond the horizon of cognition but are accessible to us, to some degree, through other channels. The apprehension of God through negation thus has a real effect on consciousness — the "Ein" sends out distant, dim rays that flicker and signal to us that there is a further horizon beyond the horizon, a being more being, more truly existent, than what we are currently capable of containing. The effect is, above all, one of humility, of wonder and refinement, of openness to what lies beyond, and of an infinite possibility to advance, to rise.

Both these sides of the apprehension of God in Judaism — the aspect that fills the divine concept with "the good," and the aspect that empties it as "the holy" — are critical for preserving the divine concept as it needs to be. Without the transcendence of the divine, we would be left with a mere synonym for the human morality we already hold, lacking a heavenly horizon and lacking any unique, absolute validity; we would thereby give up on a God of revelation, of breaking through the existing human-natural order. "God" without holiness, pictured only out of the human image of the picture of moral good, no longer arouses awe, exaltation and honor, and has no power to lift us from earthly planes to heavenly heights, or to direct our cultural consciousness toward new moral horizons. Conversely, without a constant inflow of positive, moral content, from our human system of concepts, into the name of God — without our identifying, to some degree, God with the good, as the latter is known to us in our inner consciousness — a severe "vacuum" is created within the content of the divine concept. Such a vacuum necessitates a seepage of other forces and contents into that empty concept, and so "God" becomes filled with thick, dark, imaginative pictures — ones that do not draw from the point of the good.

**E.**

The dialectical picture drawn above in the theological context faithfully reflects the general state of affairs in the relationship between religiosity-of-the-good and religiosity-of-the-holy as well. Ideal Jewish religiosity — the way of Torah — is: "hold fast to this, and also from that do not withdraw your hand." [16] There does not seem to be any traditional Jewish school of thought that has decided, unequivocally, to prefer and choose one side over the other. The religious semantic space must always remain bound to both these cords, the good and the holy, inseparably.

When the religious person lets go of the good, and of the identification between the divine and the good, religion can turn into a "drug of death," a source of self-alienation and needless asceticism, or even fuel for the bonfire of human violence that sets tribe against tribe. When a complete partition is left standing between our natural morality "from below" and the content of heavenly holiness "from above," religion indeed becomes sealed off and estranged from life and from morality. Religious interpretation of the sources of revelation requires, as noted above, some inner compass to guide it; and when moral intuitions are blocked from taking part in the interpretive process, the result is not only a fundamentalist position loyal solely to the plain sense of the verses, but a constant drift toward the stance of "the opposite is more plausible" — toward opinions and deeds that demonstrate absolute devotion specifically to what lies beyond the world, rather than to what is good for oneself, for the other, and for the real world. Such a process — certainly together with the historical context of reaction against currents of secularization and modernity — rolls religious conception and law into becoming enemies not only of what is pleasant and easy, but even of the voice of life itself, of natural morality and of the heart's own logic.

Moreover, in such a state, religion — even religion whose contents emphasize "love your neighbor as yourself" and declare that "its ways are ways of pleasantness" — can easily deteriorate into a fanatical, coarse religion that unknowingly projects all our crude psychic contents onto the religious plane. Nothing protects the Torah and "the will of God" from turning into zealous wrath, a closed doctrine and an arbitrary law that, rather than sweetening life and the world, oppose and lay them waste. [17] For if religion is not seated upon the moral motive, upon the point of goodness, kindness and purity of heart, it must necessarily recruit other, lower, even destructive driving forces from within the soul. And indeed, it seems that many prophets warned of exactly this, standing opposed to a religious worldview that preferred ritual over justice and kindness — a worldview expressed in bloodshed and oppression, but to some extent also in idolatry.

On the other hand, when the religious person bound to the good lets go of the transcendent source of the morality he seeks to hold onto — of aspirations to holiness and the sublime — and flattens his religious world onto the horizontal plane of man-and-world, of social morality and circles of justice, then he loses God, and his world becomes secularized in his own hands. When the word of God calling to him can be heard only as whatever he already, in advance, sees as fitting, beautiful and proper, he no longer has any real bond to God; he no longer holds, in any way, onto the eternity, majesty and sublimity of the divine, even if the name of Heaven still

remains current on his lips. It is hard to imagine such a religiosity preserving the elements of revelation and holiness for long, since these are perceived, almost necessarily, only as "tactics" and "counsel" for directing the person toward the moral good he already possesses anyway, in his mundane consciousness. It is true that religious language grants a space of meaning within which the moral will and the aspiration to do good can be placed at the center of life, and so it seems to remain useful even once it has been emptied of any real transcendent dimension. But in truth, such a religious language has nothing left to stand on; in the end, the religious fervor will subside, the heavenly force will be forgotten, and life will simply continue on its natural course, along the way of the world that preceded the Torah. This may not be as terrifying a picture as that of coarse, fanatical religion, but there is reason to argue that, absent a vertical dimension and a heavenly horizon, even a culture or mentality directed at the moral good will sink into a mire of materialism, selfishness and coarseness.

The dialectic, then, must be preserved. Judaism directs us toward a constant dance between the two spaces, toward a worldview that contains a logical and existential contradiction regarding the primacy of the holy over the good, or the good over the holy. Both approaches are necessary, both are true and desirable, and yet it is not within our power to fully reconcile them, but only to move between them, back and forth. At the focus of basic, everyday religious consciousness, we do indeed picture God as good in the simple, familiar sense; in this way we can walk in His ways, do what is upright and good in God's eyes, and cleave to Him and to the measures by which He deals with us — kindness, justice, compassion, forgiveness and love. Except that, always, at the outer edge of the divine concept, is preserved the image of the fire of infinity standing above and outside all that is familiar to us — "Take good heed to yourselves, for you saw no manner of form on the day the LORD spoke to you at Horeb, out of the fire." [18] We must forever be careful not to submerge "the will of God" entirely within our own moral outlook; revelation obligates us in a primary and absolute way, and calls us onto new and strange paths, in which we believe there is revealed a good that lies beyond the good we already know. And yet, the two horizons — revelation and morality — are not wholly separate from one another, and our striving is always to draw them closer together and merge them as much as we possibly can.

## **F.**

Presenting so severe a dichotomy at the base of the religious conceptual world raises a question about the unity of religious consciousness. That is — if the "bottom-up" religious person places at the center of his world moral intuition and his inner demand to do good for the world, while at the center of the world of the "top-down" religious person there stand divinity and command that are separate from, and alienated from, this world and from human moral good — how can the two dwell together under one roof? How is a unified, unfragmented religious existential consciousness even possible, one that holds two opposing pictures at the very core of religious intention? How and why does the conceptual contradiction we have demonstrated, regarding "which comes first, the good or the holy," not constantly surface into conscious awareness?

Without wishing to negate the force of other possible explanations, I want to suggest that, on the existential plane, holiness and goodness share a single channel; there is an experience, or a psychic pathway, that gives expression at once to the aspiration to holiness and to the pursuit of moral good. What is common to the religious, existential experience of both religious spaces is that both the good and the holy call upon the person to go beyond himself; both demand that the person step outside the narrow circle of himself, of bodily inclination, comfort and self-centeredness, toward action in a different direction. The core of the aspiration to do good lies in the power of an inner will directed outward, toward the other — empathy, fellowship and kindness are directed toward a concrete human other, while more general values such as integrity, equality and human rights are directed toward society, or toward human culture as a whole. The aspiration to holiness — for whose sake a person seeks to cleave to a God who is supreme and elevated above all — draws, in a certain sense, on a similar psychological root: the wish and the need to bind life to something that lies above and beyond it, so as to grant it sense and a feeling of meaning. A God who is transcendent, and who nonetheless turns toward us and reveals Himself to us in order to give us Torah and illumination, allows me to bind my temporary and fragile existence to an eternal, mighty Rock, and to elevate my life to a supreme, valid plane of being.

Both identities, then, push toward surrender to an otherness identified as higher and worthier than wallowing in the narrow, closed circle of the self. The need for such surrender is a central force in the psychic being of a person; it is what constitutes his life as having value and meaning, as worth living.[19] For this reason, in everyday religious experience, one can generally carry both these "packs" together without our hearts sensing any contradiction or tension between them. The religious person acts properly both from the side of morality and from the side of revelation together; his will to fulfill the word of God and his will to do what is good and right align within him, since they draw from a single root inside him.

## G.

Unlike the everyday plane, on which the good and the holy dwell in one shared space against the other forces and desires that run through the soul, on the more general religious plane — that of worldview, and of religious society and culture — the distinction between a religiosity whose core is the good and a religiosity whose core is the holy carries far-reaching meanings and considerable consequences for religious ethos, interpretation and halakha. This is not only a matter of scenarios in which there is a clear conflict between human morality and the plain sense of the words of revelation or of halakha. As stated above, religiosity of the good draws religious interpretation toward channels close to the heart, toward the moral and evaluative intuition of the community — which, by its very nature, is bound up with, and influenced by, the surrounding culture; religiosity of the holy, by contrast, out of an intention to set the religious space apart and to distinguish it from the profane, from the natural and from the human, draws interpretation toward directions opposed to all of these.

In different places and periods, Judaism has leaned toward one side or the other, in accordance with cultural and historical factors. In the modern era, it seems that the hand of religiosity-of-the-holy has gained the upper hand; this pushed aside, or caused to be forgotten, sources bearing the primacy of the good, and shaped an Orthodox Judaism that constitutes a reaction, opposed to and struggling against the human culture of its time — a culture characterized by the crowning of human autonomy, and by an emphasis on naturalness, freedom and secularization. In our own day, it seems that the two religious spaces of meaning overlap with an ever-widening sociological division among different religious publics, and especially within modern Orthodoxy, or religious Zionism, which stand precisely at the fault line. On the one hand, conservative forces within Judaism reinforce the dominance of the holy, understand and constitute Judaism as a "top-down" religion, and wall off religious interpretation from any human-autonomous touch steeped in modernity and secularization. On the other hand, liberal forces establish Judaism upon a foundation of morality and doing good, constitute it as a "bottom-up" religion, and stitch interpretation and halakha to a rational, moral anchor, one befitting the values and beliefs of a person living in our world.

Both warring sides level heavy accusations, or arguments, against the other. The people of holiness argue that the liberals profane the content of Judaism, empty it of its holiness and of its divine source, and flatten it into a thin, apologetic echo of the prevailing moral fashions of the world. The people of the good argue that the conservatives sever the Torah and the commandments from their original purpose of being "righteous statutes and judgments" that adorn the nation with the wisdom and understanding that characterize it, and thereby create a distorted Judaism that has stopped directing its ways toward the attributes of God, who desires life and goodness, justice and judgment, kindness and compassion.

In my view, one can only acknowledge that there is a great deal of truth in both critiques. A true Judaism cannot make do with only one of the two viewpoints; it is neither purely "top-down" nor purely "bottom-up." A correct understanding of the divine concept, of revelation, of Torah and of halakha, must always walk in both spaces at once — sometimes preferring the holy, sometimes the good; sometimes drawn toward the transcendent and the alienated, sometimes toward the intuitive and toward the morality of the heart.

## H.

What is the vision, the hoped-for future, envisioned by religiosity of the holy, and what is envisioned by religiosity of the good?

Religiosity of the good draws its wellsprings of inspiration for its vision of redemption from the life we already know. The raw materials for concocting this picture of redemption are the sides of life that already shine within us with a light of goodness; we envision and imagine a world in which the shining of faces, fellowship, love, rest, knowledge and delight are all strengthened. The image is of a world like our own, but sweetened, cleaner and purer — as though we had

opened, from memory, a small capsule holding a moment of happiness, and spread it wide to color everything.

The redemption pictured by religiosity of the holy looks different. Its contours are tied to the revelation of a light beyond the power of our apprehension in this world — the familiar heavens split open, the earth is renewed, and something no eye has ever seen shines forth in the world. The images are of the return of the primordial light of the very first day of creation, of a complete and sharp transformation of the orders of life and the laws of nature, of a miraculous elevation of the world toward a new and heavenly horizon.

But the horizon truly hoped for is the wondrous merging of the two perspectives: "On that day the LORD shall be one, and His name one."

## Notes

1. Translation: "Holiness is a word unto itself, and the rest come from it."
2. Translation: "What is hateful to you, do not do to your fellow. This is the whole Torah, and the rest is commentary."
3. Plato's Writings [Hebrew edition], vol. 1, pp. 255–278.
4. Ibid., p. 262.
5. Ibid., p. 267.
6. Gen. 18:19. There are, of course, other ways to interpret this verse.
7. "And Abraham drew near and said: Will You also sweep away the righteous with the wicked?" (Gen. 18:23); "But Abimelech had not come near her, and he said: LORD, will You slay a nation, even though righteous?" (Gen. 20:4); "And they fell upon their faces and said: O God, God of the spirits of all flesh, shall one man sin and will You be angry with the whole congregation?" (Num. 16:22); see also Gen. 4:13–14 (Cain) and many other places and figures.
8. "And you shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt, and the LORD your God redeemed you; therefore I command you this thing today" (Deut. 15:15, regarding the commandment to give gifts to a freed servant); "For it is his only covering, it is his garment for his skin; in what shall he sleep?" (Ex. 22:26, regarding the prohibition on keeping a poor man's garment overnight as a pledge); "That your manservant and your maidservant may rest as well as you" (Deut. 5:14, regarding the prohibition of labor on the Sabbath); and more.
9. "And what great nation is there that has statutes and judgments so righteous as all this Torah, which I set before you this day?" (Deut. 4:8); "He has told you, O man, what is good, and what the LORD requires of you: only to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God" (Micah 6:8); "For I am the LORD who exercises kindness, judgment and righteousness in the earth, for in these I delight, says the LORD" (Jer. 9:23); and more.
10. Guide of the Perplexed, III:26.
11. Deut. 7:7.
12. Isaiah 55:9.
13. Job 38:1–5, 17–18.
14. "And he said, Lay not your hand upon the lad, neither do anything to him; for now I know that you are a God-fearing man, seeing you have not withheld your son, your only son, from Me" (Gen. 22:12).
15. See BT Sukkah 5a: "The Shekhinah never descended below, nor did Moses and Elijah ever ascend above."
16. Eccl. 7:18.
17. I think — and I say this with considerable reservation — that one can view the two Abrahamic religions that emerged out of Judaism as a controlled experiment in a different mixture of the components of the good and the holy. Christianity identified the core of religiosity with the practice of virtuous character traits, and receded from the practical commandments (whose source is revelation) — but in doing so, blocked, in many respects, breakthrough and development, a forward movement of history. Islam, by contrast, appears to have shifted its



center of gravity almost exclusively to the dimension of holiness and revelation — but pays, today, a heavy price of fundamentalism, religious war and bloodshed in the name of that very holiness.

**18.** Deut. 4:15.

**19.** In the psychological teaching of Viktor Frankl, founder of the method of logotherapy, the key point of mental health is the search for meaning and its realization. According to Frankl, there are many kinds of meaning that people can give to their lives, but what is common to all of them is the trait of "self-transcendence," found in any goal directed outward, beyond the pursuit of pleasure and the chasing of happiness. See, for example: